

The banned list and the scoring card

The two tools every piece passes through before I see it. Paste the banned list into your voice document as written; it is generic on purpose, so all of it transfers. Then score every draft on the card, and let the thresholds decide, not your mood.

NEVER USE

CATEGORY	BANNED
Punctuation	The long dash, in every context. Use a comma, a colon or a full stop.
Structures	"Not X, it is Y." "No longer X. Now Y." Any seesaw of the same shape.
Fragments	One-word sentences used for drama. Ever.
Filler emphasis	exactly, truly, genuinely, simply, literally, absolutely, incredibly
Vocabulary	delve, leverage, robust, unlock, elevate, seamless, landscape, realm, tapestry, testament, navigate (figurative), harness, embark
Openers	"In today's fast-paced world", "Let's dive in", "Picture this", "Here's the thing"
Closers	"At the end of the day", "The bottom line is", any summary that repeats the opening
Hedges	"It is worth noting", "It is important to remember", "Some might say"

Add to it whenever you catch something twice. A word caught once is chance; a word caught twice is a habit the machine has, and habits belong on the list.

SCORE EVERY DRAFT, 1–10

DIMENSION	THE QUESTION
Originality	Could a competitor have published this?
Voice	Rules followed, and does it sound like a person?
Craft	Structure, rhythm, an ending that lands.
Usefulness	Can the reader do something differently now?
Distinctness	How far from the last twenty pieces?

THEN LET THE SCORE DECIDE

SCORE	ACTION
Below 6	Reject. Reroll or drop.
6 to 7	Queue with edits.
8	Publish.
9 to 10	Publish, then work out what was different.
Judge failed	Treat as 6. Never auto-publish, never delete.

Run the gate against anything you wrote this week. If nothing gets rejected, the gate is too soft, and volume without a working gate is how my first 200 pieces all got titles starting with "The".